

Step 7: The request reaches the host computer, which runs server software that enables the host to separate the actual request from all the scores of packets of data received.

Step 8: The Web host now sends back to the client PC (from where the request originated) the specific Web page. If the request is a search, then the host computer executes a database search and sends back the results of the search in the form of a Web page. Databases and other such applications on the computer are managed through a common gateway interface (CGI), which forwards the request to a separate database server if necessary.

Step 9: From here on, the process reverses, in a way. The packets of data sent by the Web host are routed back to the client PC through routers and gateways.

Step 10: The client PC (your computer) receives the packets of data, makes sense out of it all using TCP/IP and more, and bingo—there's the Web page on the screen!

This whole process, which we've laboriously waded through, happens in just a few seconds.

2.2 How Web Site Statistics Are Calculated

A lot of nefarious activities occur in the virtual world, and the reason for this is the popular impression that the Web is a place where you can remain anonymous. This, however, is a myth.

While things like your name and residential address can remain secret while you're surfing the Internet (unless you go ahead and volunteer the information), most Web sites collect information about the visitors to their sites while they're sending their Web pages to your PC. This is known as "Web tracking," "Web server analysis," or the reporting of Web site statistics. Web Tracking is, basically, the process of using Web site statistics and analysis tools to determine who is visiting a particular Web site, how they got there, how long they hang around, and what they do once they arrive—in short, the study of information-seeking behaviour. In order to do so, the Web sites usually incorporate tracking software—or Traffic Reporting Software—within the programming content.